

The Omnidirectional VR treadmill

After vision, and hands, the crucial aspect missing from Virtual reality was locomotion. Joysticks have been and still were the main interface to move around the virtual world, creating a major disparity in experience between moving around in the real world and in the virtual one. Until the Omni was conceptualized. Visualised as an omnidirectional treadmill meant to sense actual feet movement to translate the same into in-game movements, Jan Goetgeluk, CEO of Virtuix, quit his investment banking job and dedicated 12 months with \$200,000 to develop a prototype. That prototype consisted of dummy shoes and used a Kinect sensor and was demoed in the 2013 EEE.

This was soon followed by a Kickstarter campaign that received a lot of backers and was officially endorsed by Oculus' Palmer Luckey. The campaign overshot its initial goal of \$150,000 within 3 hours of being posted, and went on to gather \$1.1million and became one of the highest grossing technology kickstarters. Quite infamously it was rejected investment on Shark Tank, but that didn't put Jan down as the company went on to gather \$8million in additional funding. The final finished version was demonstrated at CES2015.

The first commercial shipping of the Omni was done in December 2015 to one of the first Kickstarter backers. The final product is a peripheral in a more complete VR experience that already consists of a VR headset - almost any will do. Along with the oval shaped platform that the player stands on, the setup consists of :



You don't have to worry about looking out of place anymore. It is your own personal cheatcode to a VR arena in your backyard.